

Cattle and relatives

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Mammalia
ORDER	Artiodactyla
FAMILY	Bovidae
SPECIES	279

The species that make up this family—the bovids—form a highly diverse group. Members include cattle (wild and domesticated) and their immediate allies (such as bison); sheep and goats and their relatives (such as the chamois); and antelopes (such as the impala), which is a

catch-all term for bovids with long, slender limbs. The highest diversity of bovids occurs in Africa, where each species occupies a slightly different niche. They are also found in Eurasia and North America, and a number of species have been introduced to Australasia. Bovid mostly prefer grassland, desert, scrub, and forest habitats.

Anatomy

Although bovids exhibit a wide range of body forms, from sleek, graceful gazelles to the massive, stocky buffalo, all species have unbranched horns consisting of a keratin sheath surrounding a bony core. Unlike the antlers in deer, horns are never shed,

and in most species they are present in both sexes. Horns may be straight, curved, or spiraled; keeled, ridged, or smooth; short or long. All have pointed tips.

Bovids have divided (“cloven”) hooves: the weight of the animal rests on the 2 central toes of each

foot (a pair of small lateral toes is also usually present). The tail varies from small and triangular to long and tufted, and the coat may be smooth and sleek or long and shaggy. Since bovids are often hunted by large predators, they have large, sideways-facing eyes (for good all-around vision); long, mobile ears; and an acute sense of smell. Most species have scent glands located on the face, between the hoofs, and/or in the groin. The glands between the hooves release a scent onto the ground that an isolated animal can follow back to the herd.

Bovids also have a 4-chambered ruminating stomach (see p.211). Food (usually grass or leaves) is taken in by the tongue and shredded by molars, and then swallowed. It is regurgitated later and chewed further.

Social systems

There is a huge variety of social and breeding systems among bovids. Duikers, for example, are solitary, and dik-diks live in pairs. The impala, however, lives in groups of a male with several females (younger and

weaker males form bachelor herds). Male gazelles are territorial: they mate with females that move in groups through their territories. Wild cattle and buffalo, on the other hand, live in less structured groups, although most of the mating is performed by the dominant males.

Bovids and people

Domestic sheep, goats, and cattle are farmed on large and small scales in most countries around the globe and are therefore of huge economic importance to people. Sheep and goats were probably domesticated 8,000–9,000 years ago, in southwest Asia, and their wild ancestors still live in the same region. Cattle, however, were domesticated about 2,000 years after sheep and goats (also in southwest Asia), but the ancestor of most domestic cattle, the aurochs, is now extinct.

Although some wild species are abundant—the wildebeest, for example, numbers in the millions—some, including several species of gazelle, are close to extinction due to hunting.



ESCAPING DANGER

Like most hoofed mammals, the common eland has keen senses, and flees when frightened or chased by predators. Despite their size and massive build, they can gallop at speeds of up to 43 mph (70 kph) and are capable of jumping 5 ft (1.5 m) in the air to clear obstacles in their path.